INTRODUCTION

Since the end of the Second World War, the international scenario has witnessed a certain urge among the states to ensure the well-being, peace and security not only of the states themselves, but also of the individual citizens. But the realization which dawned upon the states was that such endeavour can succeed only if that effort is supplemented by the cooperation of other states belonging to the same region as its. This realization became the basis of regionalism since the late 1940s. The roots of regionalism, therefore, lay in the perception of the national policy-makers that there are certain common interests shared by the states located in a particular region and that these interests could be "most efficiently and effectively promoted by the close and continuing cooperation within a regional framework".[1] Depending on the variety of interests, there arose a number of regional organizations such as the NATO, ASEAN, European Union, OPEC, the Arab League, and a host of others. Regionalism has now become a powerful force in international relations.